

## **SPECIAL ISSUE EDITOR'S INTRODUCTION**

### **CELEBRATING THE LEGACY OF THE LOUISVILLE PROJECT AND GRAPPLING WITH THE ANTIBLACKNESS STILL PLAGUING COLLEGE POLICY DEBATE**

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“Police still shooting us dead in the streets....” We thought it apropos to begin with this quote from Dr. Elizabeth “Liz” Jones, JD, PhD from her now famous first affirmative speech in 2004 when the Louisville Project took off and irrevocably changed the form and content of traditional policy debate. As I began to write this introduction in the Winter of 2020 (completed in the Summer of 2022) so much trauma has characterized the past few years. The addition of Ahmaud Aubery, Breonna Taylor, George Floyd (and many others since) to the long list of Black folks killed by state sponsored murder and the resulting Black Lives Matter protests that rocked the nation alongside a pandemic that has brought the nation to its knees, is the immanence out of which we write these words to you. I cannot help but to harken back to Dr. Jones’ words spoken almost 20 years ago when her arguments were treated as mere hyperbole by some members of the policy debate community and as a kind of unethical hubris or example of playing the race card, by others. Police are still shooting us dead in the streets, and COVID-19 is killing us at a higher rate than our white counterparts. When Dr. Jones and her debate partner, Dr. Tonya Green, PhD, (Louisville GJ) spoke out about the gratuitous violence faced by Black people in America we had few videotaped examples of police brutality that could help generate public condemnation of such practices. Most of America could pretend that there was little truth to claims about racial disparity in policing that resulted in higher rates of police shootings of unarmed Black people. In our contemporary moment the availability of cell phone cameras has resulted in too many examples to count of the gratuitous violence faced by Black people in this country.

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Anger and frustration have been bubbling up around the nation and violent assaults by white supremacists are on the rise. President Trump whipped his supporters into such a frenzy that they were willing to engage in acts of sedition and insurrection in the assault on the US capital on January 6, 2021 to overturn the legal results of the presidential election. While the racialized conflicts in the policy debate community have rarely resulted in physical violence, we are no strangers to the kind of anger and frustration that can often characterize conflicts over difference. The Black Lives Matter movement has raised the specter of police violence and state sponsored murder to a national issue creating political pressure through the mobilization of the masses into widescale protest. However, as progressive and liberals cry that Black Lives do Matter it is the how of their mattering that remains a conversation fraught with conflict. How do we make Black Lives Matter in places where the vestiges of structural racism remain active, vested, and applauded? What is the work that must be done so that Black Lives Matter in any and every space? How can Black Lives Matter in the debate space?

This special issue of Contemporary Argumentation and Debate honors the 20th anniversary of what is commonly referred to as the Louisville Project began by the Malcolm X Debate Program at the University of Louisville. In the late 90's and early 2000's the Louisville debate team re-envisioned itself under the direction of then director, Dr. Ede Warner. Warner decided to heavily recruit African American students, many with little to no prior high school experience. He demanded a team wide commitment to race-centered argumentation a change that drove out some of his white debaters that were more interested in traditional debate practice. Warner accepted that loss and focused on making the Louisville team a bastion of Black representation and Black thought in an activity that had trouble retaining any significant representation of Black people and rarely privileged conversations or debates about anti-Black racism. Warner's decision would have resounding implications for the development of policy debate more than 20 years later.

The first few years of the Louisville Project involved a number of experiments with the form and content of debate practices. Warner coached his teams to use the topic to talk about the impact of public policy on Black people. For a while they continued to have a plan-based affirmative that focused on race while using rap, hip hop and spoken word as part of their speech performance. For a few tournaments Warner experimented with replacing expert judges with lay judges. Louisville debaters were tasked with finding a person on the grounds of the college where

the tournaments would be held and offering them twenty dollars to judge the debate. It is not until the 2003-2004 school year that the Louisville students and their coaches, Ede Warner and Darryl Burch, developed the three-tier methodology which would come to characterize the Louisville Project (Dillard-Knox, 2014; Reid-Brinkley, 2019). The three-tier methodology required the use of personal experience, organic intellectuals and expert research, in building debate arguments about public policy considerations. Louisville criticized the extreme reliance on expert evidence in debate competition. They argued that such an overreliance on expertise created blinders that allowed debaters to exclude the thoughts and concerns of those most materially impacted by changes to public policy. Louisville argued that speaking from one's personal experience (particularly for Black folks) offered a different view of the potential consequences or benefits of public policies that might implicate the well-being of Black people (Dillard-Knox, 2014). Louisville believed that the common research and speech delivery practices in policy debate contributed to the inability of Black students to speak about the impact of structural racism in the face of claims of the risks of existential crises like nuclear war and climate change. For Louisville, these potential crises were used to deflect attention from harms that were provably occurring in the status quo to Black people. They were losing debates on the magnitude of their impact claims, in other words Black death could not outweigh arguments about existential threats to humanity. Black death was justifiable. Black people could be sacrificed if it saved the rest of the world.

The Louisville team's stated goal was to increase meaningful Black participation in policy debate. It is notable that Louisville did not set their goal at increasing Black participation in debate. To do so would have made Louisville just another attempt at increasing diverse representation in debate. Louisville understood that attempts to increase the numerical representation of Black people in the activity would fail if Black representation in debate was simply defined by the presence of Black bodies. The Louisville team understood that Black participation must be meaningful if the policy debate community hoped to create and retain a vibrant community of Black debaters and coaches (Warner and Bruschke, 2001). Diversity does not mean to just increase representation if Black people's criticisms and concerns can be ignored in order to maintain the smooth functioning of institutions. Diversity requires structural and cultural change. Real diversity causes shake ups as new voices and new perspectives question what has heretofore been marked as normal. In the context of diversity, normalization functions

as coercion and containment. Louisville refused both, instead they engaged in confrontational tactics to force those normal practices into the light of scrutiny.

The seeds that Louisville sowed have been reaped by generations of Black debaters that have followed. The Louisville Project was an unequivocal success, they were able to increase meaningful Black participation in debate. Their style and methods encouraged Black students to join offering them a glimpse into the creative and intellectual opportunities to be had through debate participation. Not only has there been a significant increase in the numbers of Black participants, but these students have made the study of anti-Black racism a central area of deliberation and research over the past twenty years.

The increase in meaningful Black participation has been hard fought, defined by anger, frustration, and distrust on all sides (Dillard-Knox, 2014; Reid-Brinkley, 2019). Individuals and entire programs have threatened to leave the activity in protest of both the confrontational rhetorical practices that characterized the Louisville Project and its evolution over time. In some cases, people followed through with those threats. Many traditionalists sought ways to curtail the rising tide of direct-action protests occurring in competition rounds. Measures such as austerity policies cleverly hidden in the language of anti-harassment guidelines, bringing Black debaters to the attention of white supremacists groups that targeted and threatened Black debaters who won one or both of the two major national championship tournaments, secret meetings held during a major national tournament to propose a breaking away from the current policy debate organizations to form a new organization with rules that would prevent students from tampering with the normative form of competition ( a very clear example of white flight when one considers exactly who would be locked out of competing in the new league). The early development of that organization, referred to as the Policy Research League (PRL) created such an uproar given its secret roll out and the exclusion of any debate director that had students engaged in race-centered and/or performance forms of debate, from attending the meeting. A secret document was distributed during the meeting that no invitee was able to remove from the room after the meeting to prevent leaks about the discussion and/or proof of the strategy to be used to complete the break away from the institutions currently governing policy debate. News did leak, and numerous parties invited to the meeting, including those with significant political power in the community refused to participate. It was during this time that numerous Black coaches were being backchanneled and warned that the faction of detractors that wanted to end the new forms of

resistance in debate competition were willing to release video footage of Black debaters, in particular, out of context in order to encourage colleges and universities that house these students to disband their debate programs. This effort failed after persistent push back from many in the community across a diversity of ideological commitments.

Despite the successes achieved by Black students in the activity, there is still work to be done. Mutual preference judging remains a significant problem and one of the most important means of sustaining structural racism. It is a problem that cannot be fixed by tinkering with computer algorithms. If the vast majority of Black judges are in the strike range on your teams judging preferences then your team and your university are directly contributing to structural racism in debate. Don't go to the streets and protest for Black lives to matter and then use your authority to discriminate against Black people in the spaces you are in, where you could make Black lives matter. While the essays in this special issue will be highly critical of various traditional debate practices, it is simultaneously important to note that significant shifts in the community have occurred over the last twenty years. Clash of civilization debates have trained generations of judges to consider the ideological and racial dynamics of the clash, resulting in an expansion of the middle group of judges willing to engage Kritik and performance arguments. That expansion has been necessary to the success of Black Debate. Black debaters have sought out judges that seem aligned with traditional debate who seem willing to try to fairly adjudicate clash debates. Cultivating mostly White men (as they are the majority of the judging pool), Black debaters innovate new argument frames and thoughtfully consider these judges' biases in crafting arguments. It is this reaching across the aisle that has spurred increases in success. Yet, fewer teams on the traditional side seem willing to engage in the same practice (a few teams are willing to engage a select few Black judges) of reaching across the aisle to Black judges. The strength of a "community" is determined by its members ability to value and engage one another, without that commitment, policy debate will continue to fracture along ideological and racial lines. If we value difference, then we must be willing to ground it in our norms and practices.

The essays in this special issue raise a number of questions and challenges for the policy debate community, some offering thoughts and suggestions for considering the future of the activity. Ignacio Evans' contribution, "Niggatry, Liquidation and the Timeless Struggles of Niggas in an Anti-Black World," opens the journal raising a significant question for policy debate, as well as, the academy writ large. Who is the audience for Black scholarship? What limit

does that audience place on Black scholarship? The academy requires Black scholars to write towards a majority white reading audience (especially if the scholar seeks publication of their work), but what might it look like in the field of communication if Black scholars' assumed audience is Black. Evans' essay is an experimental work attempting to have "a conversation about niggas to niggas from niggas," redefining the normative audience for academic writing. Beau Larsen's contribution, "Indebted: On Trans Argumentation's Relation to Black Radicalism in Intercollegiate Debate," argues that the development of Trans argumentation in debate is indebted to the rise of Black radical argument and praxis in policy debate. The essay engages the conflict between (White and non-Black) Trans Studies and the study of Black radicalism, arguing instead for Trans Studies, generally and within policy debate, to directly engage anti-Blackness. In "Eleazar, Native Debate and the Stakes of Concession," Taylor Brough analyzes a 1968 elegy written by an Indian College student and the development of Native Debate in policy debate to demonstrate that Native presence "frequently depends upon a disavowal of genocide, accumulation, and fungibility, even and especially as Native scholars posit sovereignty and vitality as authentic grammars of Native existence." In order to avoid the rhetorical trap of sovereignty and vitality, Brough argues that Native Debate and Native scholarship must theorize through "Native/Black entanglements" and engage the grammars of "accumulation, fungibility, and genocide."

Charles Athanasopoulos' and Corinne Sugino's, "Clash of the Uncivilized: An Alternative Approach to Policy Debate," takes up the development of Framework and the standards traditional debate uses to denigrate non-traditional interpretation and affirmation of policy debate resolutions. Engaging debate theory surrounding fiat, clash, division of ground between the negative and the affirmative, and switch-side debating, Athanasopoulos and Sugino offer "Revolutionary versus Revolutionary" debate (or "left vs left debates") as an alternative to traditional debates outright rejection of "Critical/Performance" debate. Tiffany Dillard-Knox's, "We Have a Job to Do: An Examination of the Coach's Role in the Development of a Diverse Student Population," argues that while the "Louisville Project" successfully ushered in a significant increase in "meaningful Black participation" that "there is work to be done." Dillard-Knox turns our attention to the significant role that coaches have to play beyond recruitment, in order to create best practices toward ensuring "meaningful Black participation." Dillard-Knox argues from a shift away from a solely competitive focus toward the consideration of the whole person and preparing students for a life after policy debate. In Lauren Christie's and Nick

Sciullo's, "In Honor of the Louisville Project: Allying Instead of Allyship to Support Minority Debaters," the authors critique the term "allyship" as a static notion of status rather than as a form of persistent practice. They argue it is necessary to shift to the term allying to demonstrate that allyship must be about "constant action." Rounding out the special issue is Luis Andrade's and Deven Cooper's, "Defending Whiteness: The Psychic Life of Anti-Blackness on Grindr," honors the Louisville Project, by demonstrating how the methods and practices of alternative debate forms influence the scholarly trajectory of the students who participate in its practice. Utilizing theories, such as anti-Blackness and the psychic life of racism, along with personal experience and social location, Andrade and Cooper, turn their attention to the defense of whiteness on Grindr. This article speaks to the racialized hyper-sexualization of Black men as they navigate the interracial space of Grindr.

The editors hope that this special issue will encourage more debate scholars to publish original scholarship around the issue of difference and its effects on competition and community-building. We seek to continue to extend the dialogue surrounding the divisions and fissures in our community toward the effort of broadening interest and access to competitive policy debate for a diversity of students. If our current national moments of crisis have taught us anything in recent year, it is that the ability and willingness to speak across racial, ethnic and gender lines will determine the future of this country. Policy debate is uniquely situated to broach those divides and train students to listen to one another, even when they are in conflict. The editors would like to thank all of the authors and reviewers for their hard work in producing this issue and a special thanks to Contemporary Argumentation and Debate for supporting this work.

### References

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